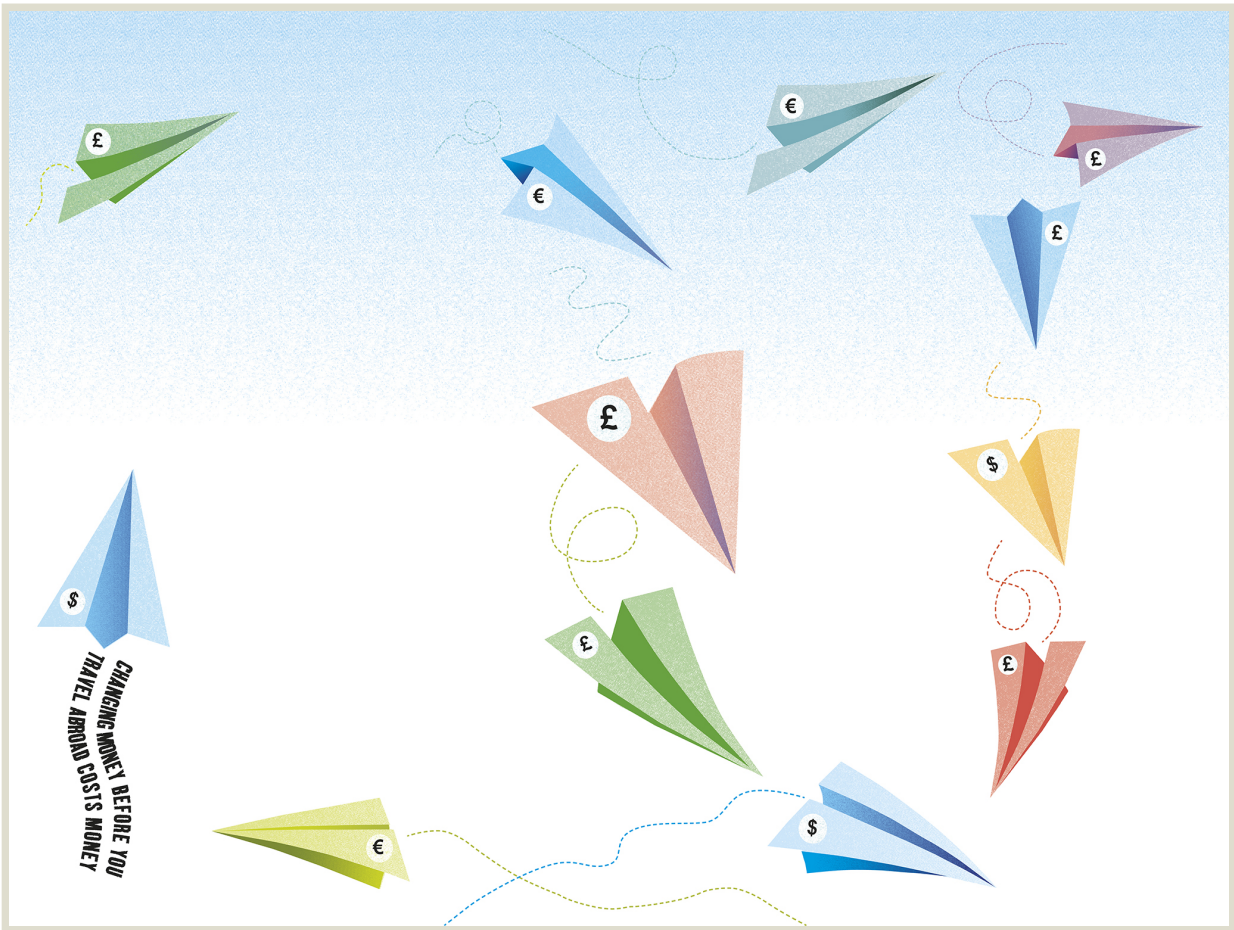




Currency costs

If you have some British pounds, for example, which you want to change into US dollars, the official exchange rate may be $\text{£}1 = \$1.50$, but the *bureau* sells at a lower rate, and buys at a higher rate. So when you go to change your money, the bank will offer you perhaps only \$1.40 for each of your pounds, effectively making 10¢ on the deal. But when get back from your trip and want to change some dollars back into pounds, the bureau will buy perhaps \$1.60 from you for £1, 10¢ more than the exchange rate. The cost of changing money varies from place to place, from as low as 5 percent to as much as 15 or even 20 percent, and is often more expensive in airports and tourist areas than in banks and post offices. Exchange rates are constantly changing, too, so it can save you money if you plan ahead and change money when the rate is in your favor, at a bank that you can trust to give you a good deal.